EPQ Shortlist: 20 Key Sources

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The 20 sources

If you read only 20 sources, read these. Each case study has three sources on its historical disruption and three on the present day, plus two for the method; 19 of the 20 are graded A or B. Numbers in brackets refer to the Top 80 accessible list. Six of the 20 (marked "not in Top 80") are paywalled or library-only, so you may need a school or public library to read them.

#	Case and period	Source	Grade	Type	What it proves for the EPQ	Reliability
1	Hormuz, Tanker War	Navias, M.S. and Hooton, E.R. (1996). Tanker Wars (not in Top 80: library book)	A2	Academic book	The standard history: Iraq attacked shipping from 1981 and Iran from 1984, long before the US convoys. Backbone for incidents per year.	Reviewed academic book; dated (1996) and needs library access.
2	Hormuz, Tanker War	UN Security Council (1987). Resolution 598 (3)	A1	Primary	The binding 15–0 ceasefire that ended the Tanker War, though Iran took a year to accept it. Formal frameworks in Period 1.	Original UN legal text; shows diplomacy helped, not how much.
3	Hormuz, Tanker War	UPI (1987). Bridgeton hits a mine (9)	B1	News at the time	The first Earnest Will convoy was mined, with no minesweepers ready. The limits of escort cooperation.	Same-day wire report, widely confirmed; blaming Iran was a Pentagon claim.
4	Hormuz, 2026	IEA (2026). Largest ever oil stock release (19)	A1	Official	32 members released 400m barrels within 11 days. Best evidence for frameworks and response speed.	The deciding body's own announcement; written to calm markets.

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5	Hormuz, 2026	Lloyd's List (2026). Gulf war risk premiums topping double-digit millions per trip (not in Top 80: paywalled)	B2	Trade press	Premiums hit 7.5% of hull value against about 5% in the Tanker War, despite more cooperation.	Shipping paper of record; quotes brokers who gain when rates rise.
6	Hormuz, 2026	Kharroubi, E. (2026). BIS Working Paper 1378 (16)	B2	Academic	Hormuz disruption raises energy prices, then cuts output and lifts consumer prices after 4–6 months. Severity: prices.	Respected central-bank research; not peer-reviewed, snippet only.
7	Suez, 1967–75	Feyrer, J. (2021). Distance, trade, and income (not in Top 80: paywalled)	A2	Peer-reviewed	The closure cut trade, but less than older estimates said, because ships rerouted. Severity in Period 1.	Peer-reviewed economics; only the abstract seen.
8	Suez, 1967–75	Egypt–Israel (1974). Disengagement Agreement, UN S/11198 (34)	A1	Primary	Clearance began only after this political deal. The key counter-argument: politics, not cooperation, reopened the canal.	Original treaty text circulated by the UN.
9	Suez, 1967–75	CTF-65 (1975). Suez Canal Clearance Final Report (37)	B1	Primary	The US–UK–French clearance took eight months once allowed, after seven years of closure. Joint operations and response speed.	The team's own official record; a US self-assessment.
10	Red Sea, 2023–26	UNCTAD (2024). Navigating Troubled Waters (43)	A1	Official data	Suez transits down 42% and container transits down 67% by early 2024: partial, not total, disruption.	UN body's own data; an early-2024 snapshot.

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11	Red Sea, 2023–26	Lloyd's List (2024). Red Sea war risk rates jump after airstrikes (not in Top 80: paywalled)	B2	Trade press	Premiums roughly tripled within a week of the January 2024 strikes. Enforcement raised priced risk.	Leading shipping paper; broker quotes, baseline-dependent.
12	Red Sea, 2023–26	Tallis, J. (2025). Won tactically but failed strategically (48)	C2	Analysis	Navies won the engagements, but traffic never came back. The only source judging the coalition against outcomes.	A US analyst's argument, not data; kept because nothing stronger does this.
13	Malacca, 1999–2008	ICC-IMB (2001; 2006). Annual report releases (55)	A1	Official data	Attacks rose from 2 to 75 in 2000, then fell to 12 by 2005; the steepest fall came before the joint patrols.	Original data from a shipowner-backed watchdog; do not mix with ReCAAP counts.
14	Malacca, 1999–2008	Poonnawatt, K. (2023). From the RMSI to ReCAAP, Marine Policy 152 (not in Top 80: paywalled)	A2	Peer-reviewed	Why the US-backed patrol plan failed on sovereignty and information sharing worked better.	Peer-reviewed, single author confirmed; paywalled.
15	Malacca, 1999–2008	Al Jazeera (2005). Piracy disappears in tsunami's wake (60)	B2	News at the time	"The tsunami seems to have really succeeded where the joint patrols could not." The main Malacca counter-argument.	Major broadcaster quoting one official weeks after the event.
16	Malacca, 2023–26	ReCAAP ISC (2026). Annual Report 2025 (62)	A1	Official data	108 incidents in 2025, 107 in the Singapore Strait, mostly petty theft, at the height of cooperation.	Original data; voluntary reporting and a stake in looking effective.

#	Case and period	Source	Grade	Type	What it proves for the EPQ	Reliability
17	Malacca, 2023–26	ReCAAP ISC (2026). Half Yearly Report Jan–Jun 2026 (63)	A1	Official data	Incidents in the straits fell 74% (80 to 21), credited to coastal-state enforcement.	Original data confirmed by several outlets; the attribution is ReCAAP's own.
18	Malacca, 2023–26	MINDEF / Republic of Singapore Navy (2025). Reply on piracy in Singapore waters (72)	B2	Official	Robberies fell from 14 in July to 1 in September 2025 after Indonesian arrests; sets out the patrol and information-sharing machinery.	Official statement defending Singapore's record; counts only its own waters.
19	Method	Marin-Ferrer, M. et al. (2017). INFORM: Concept and Methodology (75)	A1	Official methodology	The model for R = (L × S × K)^(1/3), with cooperation as coping capacity.	EU Joint Research Centre method; built for disaster risk.
20	Method	George, A.L. and Bennett, A. (2005). Case Studies and Theory Development (not in Top 80: library book)	A2	Academic book	The standard guide to process tracing, which tests why risk changed.	Leading methods book; not freshly checked.

Full references

The full reference for each of the 20 sources, in the same order as the table, with the complete web address printed so it can be followed from paper.

1. **Navias, M.S. and Hooton, E.R. (1996). Tanker Wars: The Assault on Merchant Shipping during the Iran–Iraq Conflict, 1980–1988.** I.B. Tauris (reviewed in *Iranian Studies*, Cambridge). Grade A2. Available at: https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/iranian-studies/article/abs/tanker-wars-the-assault-on-merchant-shipping-during-the-iraniraq-conflict-19801988-martin-s-navias-and-e-r-horton-london-and-new-york-ib-tauris-publishers-1996-ix-244-pp-including-appendix-notes-index-of-ships-and-general-index-cloth/555128C86253A41B2A6257F098EC20C2
2. **UN Security Council (1987). Resolution 598 (1987).** UN Digital Library, 20 July 1987. Grade A1. Available at: https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/137345

3. **UPI (1987). The supertanker Bridgeton hit an underwater mine Friday morning.** *UPI Archives*, 24 July 1987. Grade B1. Available at: https://www.upi.com/Archives/1987/07/24/The-supertanker-Bridgeton-hit-an-underwater-mine-Friday-morning/4397554097600/
4. **International Energy Agency (2026). IEA Member countries to carry out largest ever oil stock release amid market disruptions from Middle East conflict.** IEA press release, 11 March. Grade A1. Available at: https://www.iea.org/news/iea-member-countries-to-carry-out-largest-ever-oil-stock-release-amid-market-disruptions-from-middle-east-conflict/
5. **Lloyd's List (2026). Gulf war risk premiums topping double-digit millions of dollars per trip.** Lloyd's List, c. 11 March. Grade B2. Available at: https://www.lloydslist.com/LL1156586/Gulf-war-risk-premiums-topping-double-digit-millions-of-dollars-per-trip
6. **Kharroubi, E. (2026). Maritime chokepoints and the global economy: evidence from the Strait of Hormuz.** BIS Working Papers No. 1378. Grade B2. Available at: https://www.bis.org/publications/working-paper-1378-maritime-chokepoints-and-the-global-economy-evidence-strait-hormuz
7. **Feyrer, J. (2021). Distance, trade, and income – The 1967 to 1975 closing of the Suez Canal as a natural experiment.** *Journal of Development Economics* 153, 102708. Grade A2. Available at: https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jdeveco.2021.102708
8. **Egypt and Israel (1974). Agreement on Disengagement of Forces (Kilometre 101), annexed to UN document S/11198.** United Nations (UNISPAL), 18 January. Grade A1. Available at: https://www.un.org/unispal/document/auto-insert-181723
9. **Commander Task Force 65 (1975). CTF Sixty-Five Final Report: Suez Canal Clearance Operations Nimbus Star, Nimbus Moon, Nimrod Spar.** DTIC AD-A010 261. Grade B1. Available at: https://apps.dtic.mil/sti/pdfs/ADA010261.pdf
10. **UNCTAD (2024). Navigating Troubled Waters: Impact to Global Trade of Disruption of Shipping Routes in the Red Sea, Black Sea and Panama Canal.** UNCTAD Rapid Assessment, 22 February. Grade A1. Available at: https://unctad.org/publication/navigating-troubled-waters-impact-global-trade-disruption-shipping-routes-red-sea-black
11. **Lloyd's List (2024). Red Sea war risk rates see huge jump in wake of Yemen airstrikes.** *Lloyd's List*, c. 16 January. Grade B2. Available at: https://www.lloydslist.com/LL1147965/Red-Sea-war-risk-rates-see-huge-jump-in-wake-of-Yemen-airstrikes
12. **Tallis, J. (2025). How the Biden Administration Won Tactically but Failed Strategically in the Red Sea.** *War on the Rocks*, 2 April. Grade C2. Available at: https://warontherocks.com/2025/04/how-the-biden-administration-won-tactically-but-failed-strategically-in-the-red-sea/

13. **ICC International Maritime Bureau (2001; 2006). Piracy attacks rise to alarming new levels, ICC report reveals / Iraq declared new piracy hotspot.** ICC press releases on the IMB annual reports for 2000 and 2005. Grade A1. Available at: https://iccwbo.org/news-publications/news/piracy-attacks-rise-to-alarming-new-levels-icc-report-reveals/ and https://iccwbo.org/news-publications/news/iraq-declared-new-piracy-hotspot/
14. **Poonnawatt, K. (2023). Multilateral cooperation against maritime piracy in the Straits of Malacca: from the RMSI to ReCAAP. Vol. 152, article 105628.** *Marine Policy*. Grade A2. Available at: https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0308597X23001550
15. **Al Jazeera (2005). Piracy disappears in tsunami's wake.** Al Jazeera (also NBC News). Grade B2. Available at: https://www.aljazeera.com/amp/news/2005/2/1/piracy-disappears-in-tsunamis-wake
16. **ReCAAP ISC (2026). Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia: Annual Report 2025 (and press release).** ReCAAP Information Sharing Centre. Grade A1. Available at: https://recaap.org/resources/ck/files/reports/annual/ReCAAP%20ISC%20Annual%20Report%202025.pdf
17. **ReCAAP ISC (2026). Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia: Half Yearly Report, January–June 2026 (and press release).** ReCAAP Information Sharing Centre. Grade A1 (graded here). Available at: https://www.recaap.org/resources/ck/files/reports/half-year/ReCAAP%20ISC%20Half%20Yearly%20Report%202026.pdf
18. **Ministry of Defence, Singapore / Republic of Singapore Navy (2025). Reply to media query on increase in piracy in Singapore waters.** MINDEF. Grade B2. Available at: https://www.mindef.gov.sg/news-and-events/latest-releases/13oct25-mq/
19. **Marin-Ferrer, M., Vernaccini, L. and Poljansek, K. (2017). Index for Risk Management INFORM: Concept and Methodology, Version 2017.** EU Publications Office (EUR 28655 EN). Grade A1. Available at: https://doi.org/10.2760/094023
20. **George, A.L. and Bennett, A. (2005). Case Studies and Theory Development in the Social Sciences.** Cambridge, MA: MIT Press. Grade A2. No free online copy; find it in a library or bookshop. Search link: https://scholar.google.com/scholar?q=George+Bennett+2005+Case+Studies+and+Theory+Development+in+the+Social+Sciences

How the shortlist covers the question

Every case has evidence from both of its periods, and the counter-arguments are as well covered as the main argument.

Part of the EPQ	Sources (by number)
Formal frameworks	2, 4, 8, 14
Joint operations	3, 9, 12, 18
Information sharing	14, 16, 18
Response speed	4, 9, 13
Enforcement of laws	11, 17, 18
Likelihood (incidents, insurance)	1, 5, 11, 13, 16, 17
Severity (trade, duration, prices)	6, 7, 10
Counter-arguments	3, 8, 11, 12, 13, 15
Method	19, 20

Mix	Count
Official, primary and data	10
Academic and peer-reviewed	5
Trade press and news written at the time	4 (plus 1 analysis)
Grade A / B / C	12 / 7 / 1

The one C-graded source, Tallis, stays because it is the only after-the-event judgement of the Red Sea coalition. Grades and reliability notes are unchanged from the Top 100; check every figure at its source before citing it.